

文 法 Grammar

1 Short Forms

In this and the next lesson, we will learn a new paradigm of conjugation, which we will call “short forms.”¹ Compare the long forms, which we already know, and the short forms:

Present, affirmative

	long forms	short forms	
• verbs:	読みます	読む	(= Dictionary form)
• い-adjectives:	かわいいです	かわいい	(Drop です.)
• な-adjectives:	静かです	静かだ	(Replace です with だ.)
• noun + です:	学生です がくせい	学生だ がくせい	(Replace です with だ.)

Present, negative

	long forms	short forms	
• verbs:	読みません	読まない	→ More on this below.
• い-adjectives:	かわいくないです	かわいくない	(Drop です.)
(exception) いい:	よくないです	よくない	
• な-adjectives:	静かじゃないです	静かじゃない	(Drop です.)
• noun + です:	学生じゃないです がくせい	学生じゃない がくせい	(Drop です.)

Let's look at the verbs in the negative in detail. *Ru-*, *u-*, and irregular verbs conjugate differently.

Verb short forms (present, negative)

- *ru*-verbs: Drop the final る and add ない.

食べる	→	食べない
た		た
- *u*-verbs: Drop the last -u and add -anai. Verbs that have う, however, get わ instead of あ.

書く	→	書かない	会う	→	会わない
か		か	あ		あ
- irregular verbs: The vowels change.

する	→	しない	くる	→	こない
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- exception: The verb ある is totally replaced by the adjective ない.

ある	→	ない
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¹ Various names have been given to this paradigm. They include “plain forms,” “informal forms,” and “direct style.” Long forms, on the other hand, are often called “polite forms,” “formal forms,” and “distal style.”

Think of the *u*-verb conjugation as moving up and down in the *hiragana* chart. Let's take 書く for example. The dictionary form 書く is the combination of the verb base in the kanji 書 and the bottom *hiragana* of that row, く. 書きます is the combination of 書, き, and the ます ending on the right. 書かない is 書, か and ない.

	書 か	話 はな	待 ま	死 し	読 よ	作 つく	泳 およ	呼 よ	買 か	
negative	か	さ	た	な	ま	ら	が	ば	わ ²	～ない
stem	き	し	ち	に	み	り	ぎ	び	い	～ます
affirmative	く	す	つ	ぬ	む	る	ぐ	ぶ	う	= Dictionary form

2 Short Forms in Informal Speech

Close friends or family members speak with each other using short forms at the end of sentences as a sign of intimacy. The use of long forms, in contrast, tends to imply the speaker's intention to "keep a proper distance" from the listener. Short forms, then, are like talking on a first-name basis, while long forms are like using "Mr." and "Ms."

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(Between friends) A : 今日、学校に行く？ (Short form)
きょう がっこう い

Are you going to school today?

B : ううん、行かない。
い

No, I'm not.

(To a stranger) A : すみません、この電車は新宿に行きますか。 (Long form)
でんしゃ しんじゅく い

Excuse me, does this train go to Shinjuku?

B : いいえ、行きませんよ。
い

No, it doesn't.

It may not be easy to decide when it is appropriate to switch to short forms. First of all, Japanese speakers are often very conscious of seniority. A year's difference in age may in many cases totally preclude the possibility of establishing a truly "equal" relationship. Second, license to use short forms is not mutual; senior partners may feel perfectly justified in using short forms while expecting their junior partners to continue addressing them with long forms. Thus, if somebody who is older, say, your Japanese language professor, talks to you using short forms, they would be greatly surprised if you were to do the same.

² Note that we have 買わない, with わ instead of あ, because the bases of *u*-verbs ending with the *hiragana* う actually end with the consonant *w*, which remains silent in 買う and 買います, but resurfaces in 買わない.

Professor: この漢字、わかる？³ *Do you know this kanji?*

Student: はい、わかります。 *Yes, I do.*

(×うん、わかる。)

(Long form preferred, because you are talking to somebody who is older.)

In the casual conversations, you drop the question particle か, and use the rising intonation to ask a question.⁴

どんな音楽を聞く？ (×どんな音楽を聞くか？)

What kind of music do you listen to?

Also, in the spoken language, you usually drop the sentence-final だ after a な-adjective or a noun. (You keep the last だ in the written language, however.)

A: 元気？ *Are you good?*

B: うん、元気。 *Yes, I am.*

(Rather than: 元気だ。)

You keep だ when you follow it up with ね or よ.

メアリーさんは二年生だよ。 *Mary is a sophomore.*

(Rather than: メアリーさんは二年生だ。)

はい and いいえ are usually replaced by the less formal うん and ううん.

A: よくスポーツをする？ *Do you often play sports?*

B: うん、する。/ ううん、しない。 *Yes, I do. / No, I don't.*

3 Short Forms in Quoted Speech: ～と思います

To describe what you think, you use the short form, plus と思います (I think that . . .). と is a quotation particle, which does the job of both the English word “that” in indirect quotation and of quotation marks (“ ”) in direct quotation.

(私は) たけしさんはメアリーさんが好きだと思います。

I think Takeshi likes Mary.

³ Particles are more often dropped in casual speech than in careful, polite speech or writing.

⁴ We usually write the question mark at the end of such a sentence, because we cannot rely on the intonation.

To say that you *don't think* something is the case, it is more common in Japanese to say it like ～ないと思います (*I think that something is not the case*) than ～とおもいません (*I don't think*). Therefore:

(私は)メアリーさんはたけしさんが好きじゃないと思います。
わたし す おも
I don't think Mary likes Takeshi. (= I think Mary doesn't like Takeshi.)

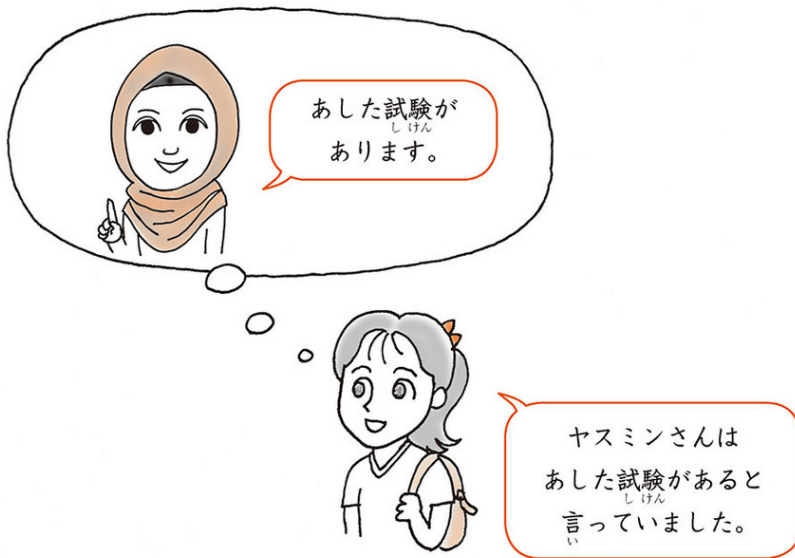
4 Short Forms in Quoted Speech: ～と言っていました

To quote a person's utterances, you use the short form plus と言っていました⁵ (They said "..."). Note that the present tense in Yasmin's original utterance is preserved in Mary's report.

ヤスミンさんは、あした試験があると言っていました。
しけん い
Yasmin said that there would be an exam tomorrow.

山下先生は結婚していないと言っていました。
やましたせんせい けっこん い
Professor Yamashita said that he is not married.

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⁵ The action in progress expression in と言っていました indicates that you were there when somebody said that, as in "I heard them saying..." If you were not there when the utterance was made, as in "(the long dead) Napoleon said...", と言いました sounds more appropriate.

5 ～ないでください

To request that someone refrain from doing something, one can use a negative verbal short form plus ください.

ここで写真を撮らないでください。

Please don't take pictures here.

verb (short, negative) + ください *Please don't...*

ないでください often is a better answer than てはいけません to a とてもいいですか question.

A: この部屋に入ってもいいですか。

May I enter this room?

B: 入らないでください。 Compare: 入ってはいけません。

Please don't.

(Implies that you are in a position of authority.)

6 Verb のが好きです/上手です

A verb short form + の turns a verb into a noun describing an action. Thus in combination with が好きです／きらいです, for example, you can describe what you like/dislike doing.

(私は) 日本語を勉強するのが好きです。

I like studying the Japanese language.

(私は) 部屋を掃除するのがきらいです。

I don't like cleaning my room.

“To be good/bad at doing something” is ～が上手です (is good at ...) and ～が下手です (is bad at ...).⁶

ロバートさんは料理を作るのが上手です。

Robert is good at cooking meals.

たけしさんは英語を話すのが下手です。

Takeshi is not a good speaker of English.

⁶ To describe one's skills or lack thereof, we also often use a different set of expressions, namely, ～がとくいです (is comfortable with ...) and ～ががてです (is uncomfortable with ...).

私は日本語を話すのがとくいです。 *I am good at/comfortable with speaking Japanese.*

person は activity (verb) のが	$\left\{ \begin{array}{l} \text{好き} \\ \text{す} \\ \text{嫌い} \\ \text{上手} \\ \text{じょうず} \\ \text{下手} \\ \text{へた} \end{array} \right\}$	です。	<i>likes doing...</i> <i>doesn't like doing...</i> <i>is good at doing...</i> <i>is poor at doing...</i>
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It is a common mistake to use the *te*-form of a verb in such contexts, misled by the association between ～ている and the verb in the *-ing* form in English.

× たけしさんは英語を話してが下手です。
えいご はな へ た

7 The Subject Particle が

Consider what ロバートさんは沖縄に行きました means. This sentence of course is about Robert and describes what he did. It is likely to be uttered when the topic of Robert has already been breached. Grammatically speaking, (1) the noun ロバート stands as the subject in relation to the verb 行く (he was the person who performed the going), and (2) the noun is, per the function of the particle は, presented as the topic of the sentence (*as for* Robert, he went to Okinawa).

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What if we both know that somebody went to Okinawa recently, and *I* know that it was Robert, but *you* don't? I will say:

ロバートさんが沖縄に行きました。 *ROBERT went to Okinawa.*
おきなわ い

This sentence means that *Robert* went to Okinawa, which in English would be uttered with an extra emphasis on the name Robert, which is the new piece of information in this sentence.

Question words like だれ and 何 in the subject of a sentence are followed by が rather than は.

だれが沖縄に行きましたか。 Compare: × だれは沖縄に行きましたか。
おきなわ い おきなわ い
Who went to Okinawa?

As we learned in Lesson 2, a question word that is the subject of a sentence is never followed by the particle は, but always by the particle が (p. 61). As we have seen, a noun that will provide the answer to such a question is also followed by the particle が.

A: どのクラスがおもしろいですか。
Which class is (the most) interesting?

B: 日本語のクラスがおもしろいです。
にほんご
Japanese class is.

A : (このクラスで)だれがめがねをかけていますか。

Who wears glasses (in this class)?

B : 山下先生がめがねをかけています。

*やましたせんせい
Professor Yamashita does.*

8 何か and 何も

The word for “something” is 何か, and the word for “anything” in negative sentences is 何も.

“Some” and “any” in

• positive statements:	何か なに	something
• questions:	何か なに	anything?
• negative statements:	何も + negative なに	not . . . anything

When 何か and 何も are used in places where the particles は, が, and を are expected, they are often used on their own, without the help of particles. We will learn in Lesson 10 what to do in cases where particles other than these are expected.

猫が何か持ってきました。

*ねこ なに も
The cat has brought something.*

猫は何か食べましたか。

*ねこ なに た
Did the cat eat anything?*

いいえ、猫は何も食べませんでした。

*ねこ なに た
No, the cat did not eat anything.*

表現ノート

ひょう げん

～する ▶ Most irregular verbs are compounds of nouns and the verb する. Here, if you have learned an irregular verb, you have also learned a noun.

verbs

nouns

勉強する

勉強

e.g. 日本語の勉強は楽しいです。

べんきょう

べんきょう

Japanese language study is fun.

to study

study

料理する

料理

e.g. ロバートさんの料理はおいしいです。

りょうり

りょうり

Robert's cooking is good.

to cook

cooking

Some of these nouns can be used as the “object” of the verb する.

私は日本語の勉強をしました。

I studied Japanese.

わたし にほんご

Compare: 私は日本語を勉強しました。

わたし にほんご べんきょう

たけしさんは部屋の掃除をしました。

Takeshi cleaned his room.

へや そうじ

Compare: たけしさんは部屋を掃除しました。

へや そうじ

You can use both these nouns and their する verbs in sentences with 好きです and きれいです, for example. You need to add の to the verbs, as we discussed in Grammar 6. Pay attention to the particles before these words, too.

日本語の勉強が好きです。／日本語を勉強するのが好きです。

I like studying Japanese.

にほんご べんきょう

にほんご べんきょう

遅い/遅く ▶ Although both 遅い and 遅く mean “late,” they have different usages, since 遅い is an adjective and 遅く is an adverb. 遅い modifies nouns or works as a predicate, and 遅く modifies verbs.

A: きのう一時に寝ました。

I went to bed at one o'clock yesterday.

いちじ ね

B: 遅いですね。

It's late.

おそ

週末には、十時ごろ起きて、遅い朝ご飯を食べます。

しゅうまつ

じゅうじ

お

おそ

あさ

はん

た

On weekends, I get up around 10:00 and eat late breakfast.

きのう、遅く寝ました。

I went to bed late yesterday.

おそ ね

You can also apply this rule to 早い/早く.

はや はや